



2023 Tennessee Drug Overdose Deaths

Tennessee Department of Health

Office of Informatics and Analytics

March 1, 2025

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Department of Health Authorization No. 355686.
This Electronic publication was promulgated at zero cost.
March 2025.

Executive Summary

In Tennessee, 3,616 people died of a fatal drug overdose in 2023. This is a 5.5% decrease from the previous year and the first time there has been a decrease in overdose deaths since Tennessee began monitoring overdose surveillance in 2013.

- In 2023, fatal drug overdoses involving opioids decreased 5% between 2022 and 2023. Deaths attributed to opioids identified as pain relievers decreased 19% and deaths attributed to illicit fentanyl decreased 3% between 2022 and 2023.
- Deaths involving stimulants experienced a 6% increase between 2022 and 2023. This is primarily driven by the 21% increase in deaths involving cocaine.
- The age-adjusted rate of drug overdose deaths among Black Tennesseans continues to be higher than White Tennesseans in 2023 (67.05 per 100,000 Tennesseans vs. 50.65 per 100,000 Tennesseans).
- In 2023, drug overdose deaths among all age groups experienced a decrease except for the under 18 years of age category which saw a 54% increase. This increase was primarily driven by an increase in deaths among children under 5 years of age.
- Data linkage conducted between vital statistics data and Prescription Drug Monitoring Program (PDMP) shows a continued decline in overdose decedents receiving opioid or benzodiazepine prescriptions in the 60 days prior to their death.
- Data linkage conducted between vital statistics data and Hospital Discharge Data System (HDDS) data shows that 1 in 5 Tennesseans experience a prior nonfatal drug overdose treated in a hospital setting in the year before death. This reiterates the importance of linkage to care efforts in Tennessee hospitals.

While drug overdose deaths have begun to decline, continued prevention and harm reduction activities are needed to maintain the decrease. Continued training and awareness of how to use naloxone and fentanyl test strips is important. Family, friends, and the general public should know how to administer naloxone to assist a person who uses drugs if an overdose occurs. Research on prevention and intervention strategies should continue to focus on populations most impacted and culturally relevant treatment and prevention options.

Introduction and Purpose

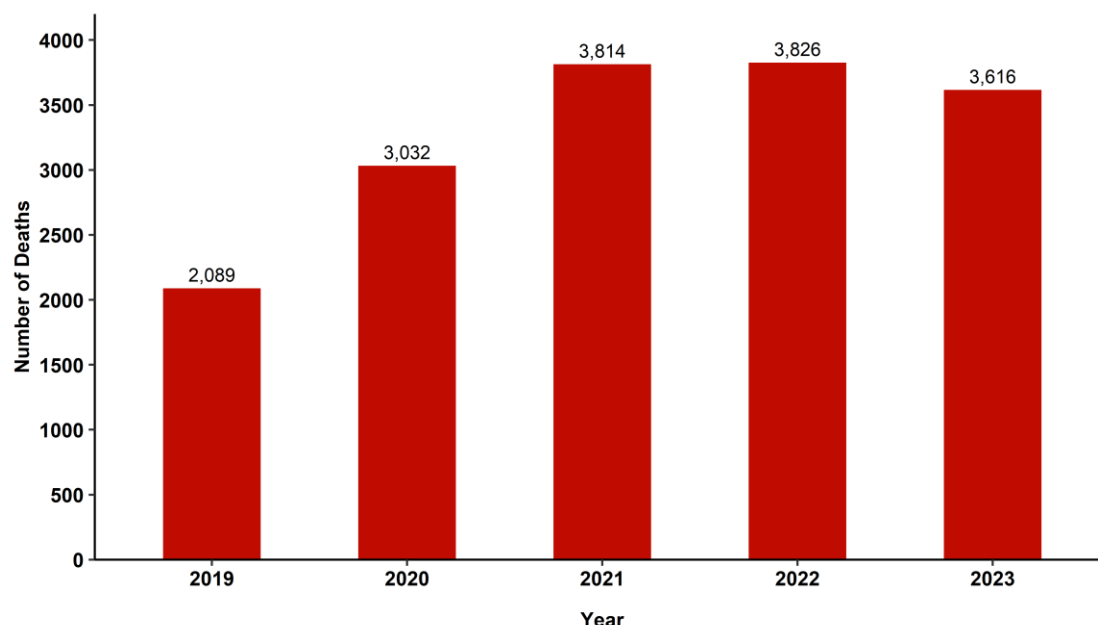
The purpose of this brief report is to describe drug overdose deaths among Tennessee residents in 2023, with an emphasis on providing useful data to stakeholders of Tennessee Department of Health (TDH) at the regional and county levels. Results presented here are derived from Vital Statistics death certificate data as well as data from Tennessee's prescription drug monitoring program, the Controlled Substance Monitoring Database (CSMD).

Definitions

- Fatal drug overdose
 - A fatal drug overdose is classified medically as a “death resulting from drug poisoning.”
 - To be classified as a fatal overdose, the underlying cause of death on a death certificate must be designated as a drug poisoning. While drugs may contribute to deaths, only cases that designate drug poisoning as the underlying cause of death on death certificates are classified as fatal overdoses by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). TDH provides death certificate data to CDC and they provide the final classifications and coding for the causes of death. For this reason, it is possible that local medical examiners may consider rates of overdose death to be different than the final, official statistical data.
- Contributing cause of death
 - In addition to the underlying cause of death, a death certificate may include multiple contributing causes of death. Once a death is designated as an overdose, the contributing causes provide data on the types of drugs that were present in the body of the decedent, as identified through a toxicology report. Of note, contributing causes of death are coded using ICD-10 codes, so drugs for which a code does not exist would not be identified in this way.
- Literal text on death certificates
 - In addition to coded data available in the underlying and contributing causes of death fields, there are text fields available that may provide additional information. For example, no ICD-10 code currently exists that identifies fentanyl specifically. The analytics team instead uses a text search to identify fatal overdoses involving fentanyl.
- Controlled Substance Monitoring Database (CSMD)
 - CSMD of Tennessee includes data on controlled substances that are dispensed. For our analyses, we only include CSMD data for individuals who are Tennessee residents.

State-level Overview 2019 - 2023

Drug Overdose Deaths among TN Residents, 2019-2023

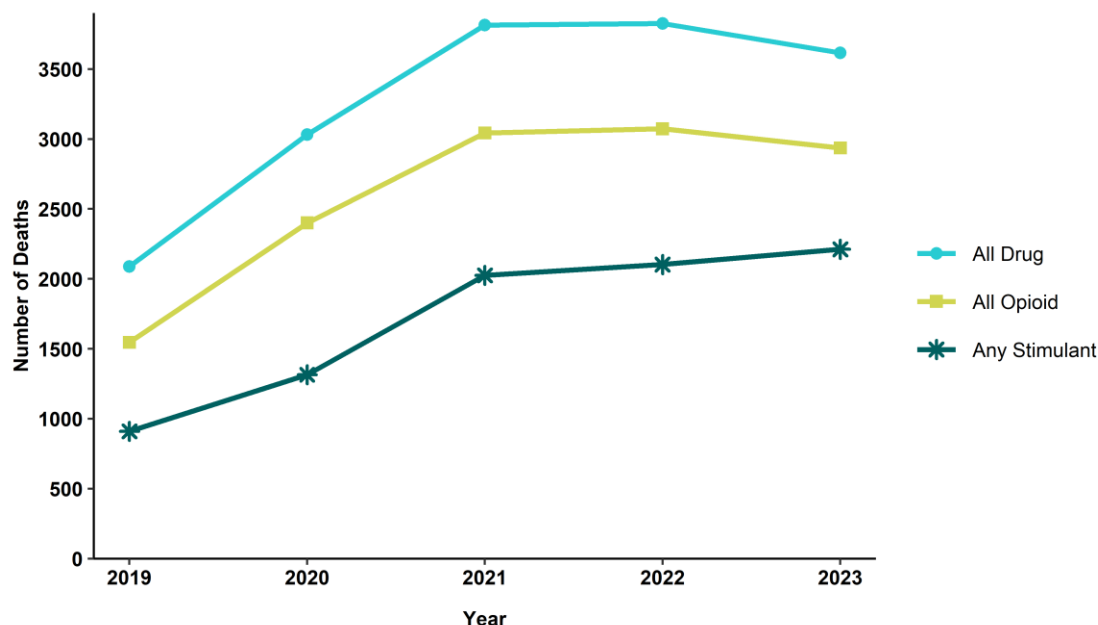


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

In 2023, drug overdose deaths declined for the first time since Tennessee began monitoring overdose data in 2013. While the number of overdose deaths in 2023 remains high, this initial decrease is an encouraging trend.

The intent, sometimes referred to as manner of death, is the general classification of how the injury led to the death. In 2023, 96% of all drug overdose deaths (n=3,486) in Tennessee were due to unintentional poisoning, while 2% of overdose deaths were intentional.

Number of Overdose Deaths by Drug Type* among TN Residents, 2019-2023



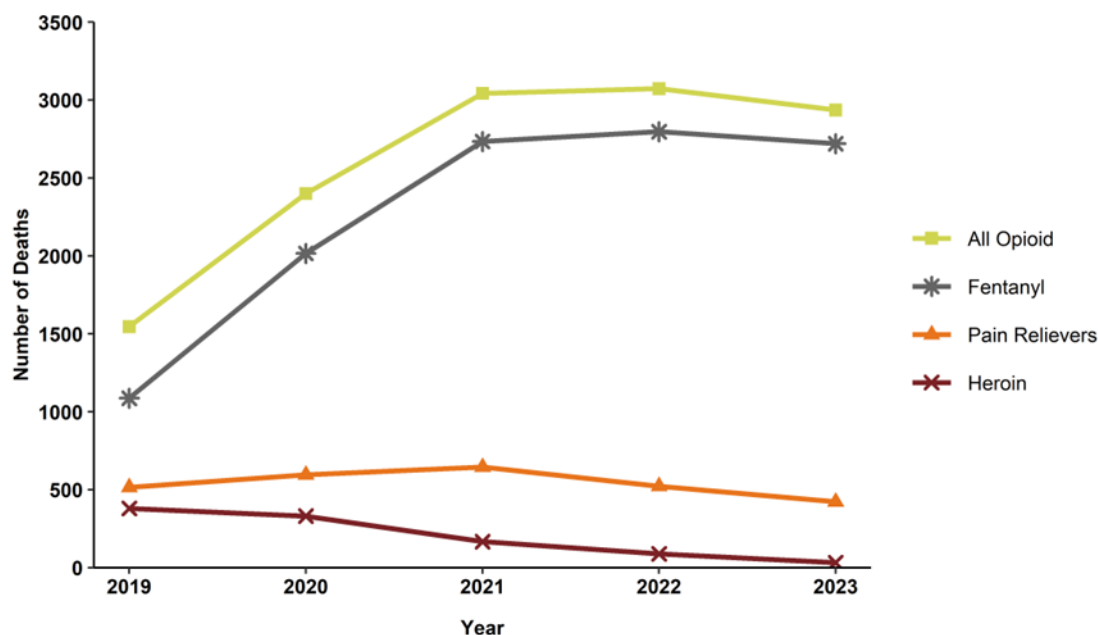
Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of Overdose Deaths among TN Residents by Drug Type					
Type	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
All Drug	2,089	3,032	3,814	3,826	3,616
All Opioid	1,546	2,400	3,043	3,073	2,936
Any Stimulant	910	1,315	2,025	2,103	2,212

In 2023, the count of overdose deaths attributed to opioids decreased while the count of overdose deaths attributed to stimulants increased.

**Drug categories are not mutually exclusive. An overdose may have involved multiple types of opioids, non-opioids, or both. Due to improvement in text searches, opioid counts (fentanyl specifically) from previous years may be updated to reflect the new criteria.*

Number of Opioid Overdose Deaths* among TN Residents, 2019-2023



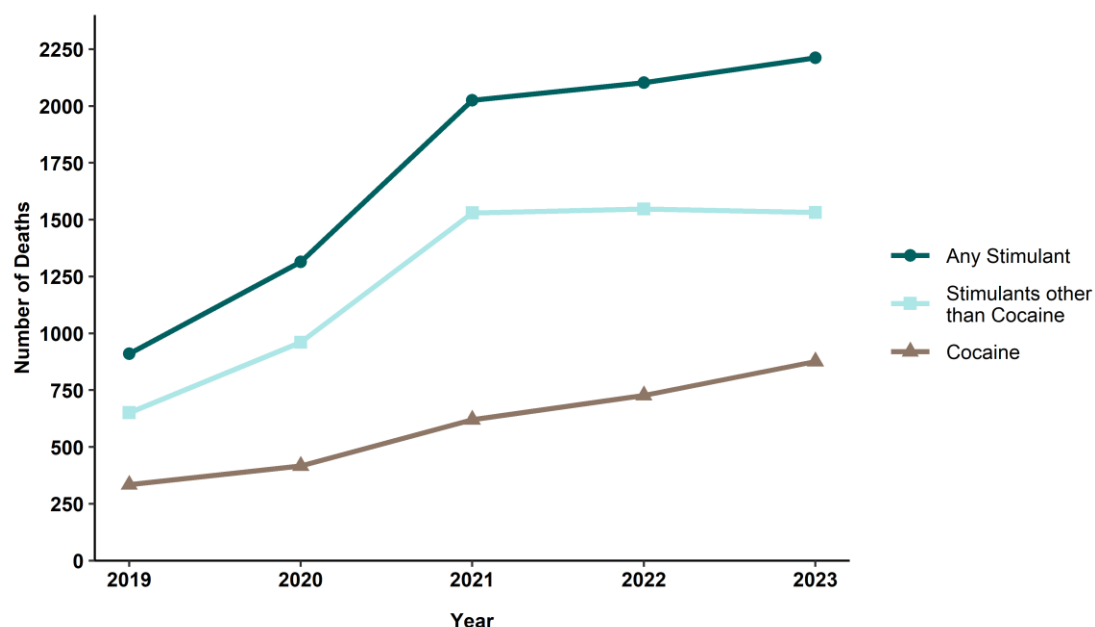
Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of Opioid Overdose Deaths among TN Residents by Drug Type					
Type	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
All Opioid	1,546	2,400	3,043	3,073	2,936
Fentanyl	1,087	2,016	2,734	2,797	2,720
Pain Relievers	515	595	645	522	422
Heroin	380	331	167	89	32

Opioids have consistently played a role in drug overdose deaths among Tennessee residents and accounted for 80% of overdose deaths in 2023. This is a 5% decrease from 2022. Most opioid overdoses are attributed to illicit fentanyl. Deaths involving opioids identified as pain relievers (i.e., those typically obtained through a prescription) have been declining since 2021. Deaths involving heroin have decreased significantly since 2019.

**Drug categories are not mutually exclusive. An overdose may have involved multiple types of opioids, non-opioids, or both. Due to improvement in text searches, opioid counts (fentanyl specifically) from previous years may be updated to reflect the new criteria.*

Number of Stimulant Overdose Deaths* among TN Residents, 2019-2023



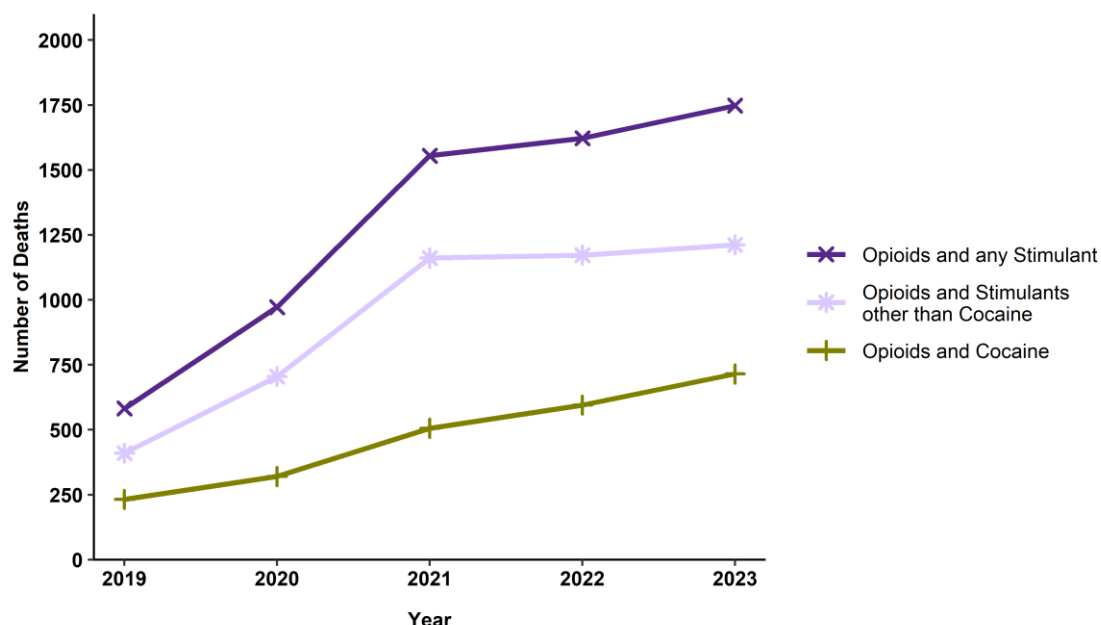
Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of Stimulant Overdose Deaths among TN Residents					
Type	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Any Stimulant	910	1,315	2,025	2,103	2,212
Stimulants other than Cocaine	615	961	1,530	1,547	1,532
Cocaine	334	417	620	727	876

Deaths involving any stimulants have increased 143% from 2019 to 2023. Deaths involving cocaine increased 162% from 2019 to 2023. Deaths involving stimulants other than cocaine, a category that includes primarily methamphetamine, experienced a decrease in 2023. This category had previously been increasing from 2019 to 2022.

**Drug categories are not mutually exclusive. An overdose may have involved multiple types of opioids, non-opioids, or both. Due to improvement in text searches, opioid counts (fentanyl specifically) from previous years may be updated to reflect the new criteria.*

Number of Stimulant and Opioid Overdose Deaths* among TN Residents, 2019-2023



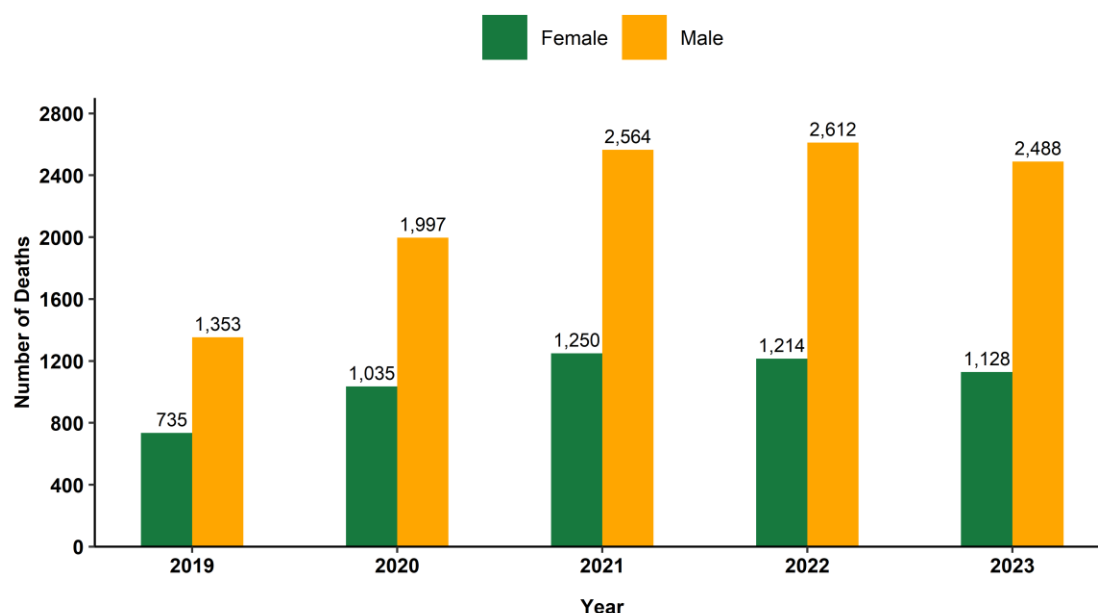
Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of Stimulant and Opioid Overdose Deaths among TN Residents					
Type	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Opioids and Any Stimulant	582	972	1,555	1,622	1,748
Opioids and Stimulants other than Cocaine	410	705	1,161	1,172	1,212
Opioids and Cocaine	232	320	506	595	715

Deaths involving both opioids and stimulants increased in 2023. This increase has occurred for all opioid and stimulant combinations over the past five years. In 2023, 79% of stimulant-involved deaths also involved an opioid. Of these deaths (n=1,748), the opioid most frequently involved was fentanyl (97%).

**Drug categories are not mutually exclusive. An overdose may have involved multiple types of opioids, non-opioids, or both. Due to improvement in text searches, opioid counts (fentanyl specifically) from previous years may be updated to reflect the new criteria.*

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Sex among TN Residents, 2019-2023

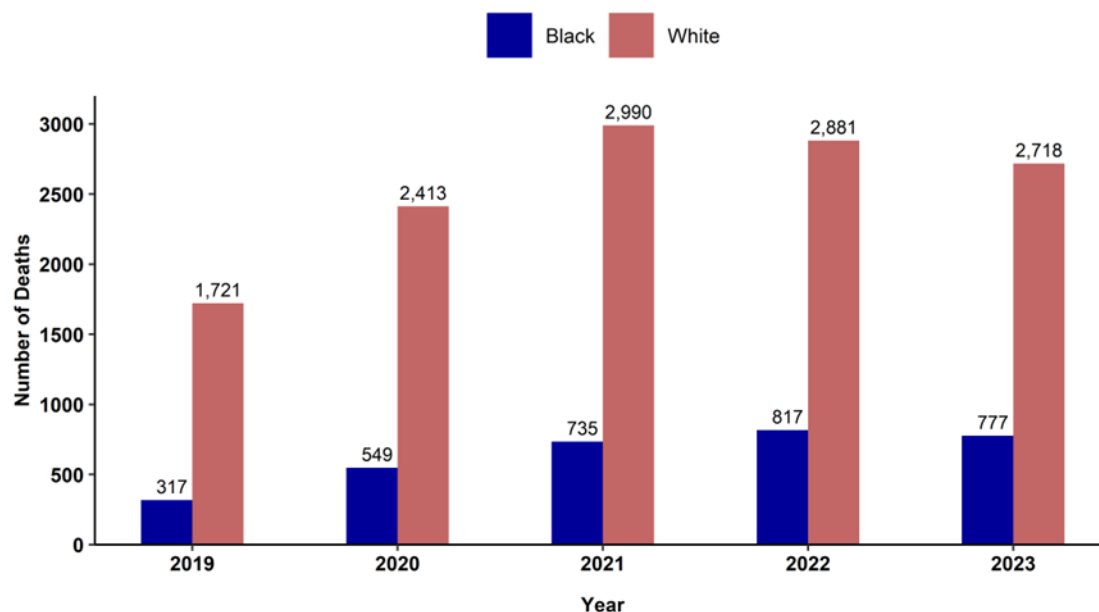


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Sex among TN Residents					
Sex	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Female	735	1,035	1,250	1,214	1,128
Male	1,353	1,997	2,564	2,612	2,488

Overdose deaths among both males and females decreased in 2023. Over the past five years, approximately two-thirds of overdose deaths were among males. Overdose deaths among females increased by 70% from 2019 to 2021 and have been declining since.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Race among TN Residents, 2019-2023



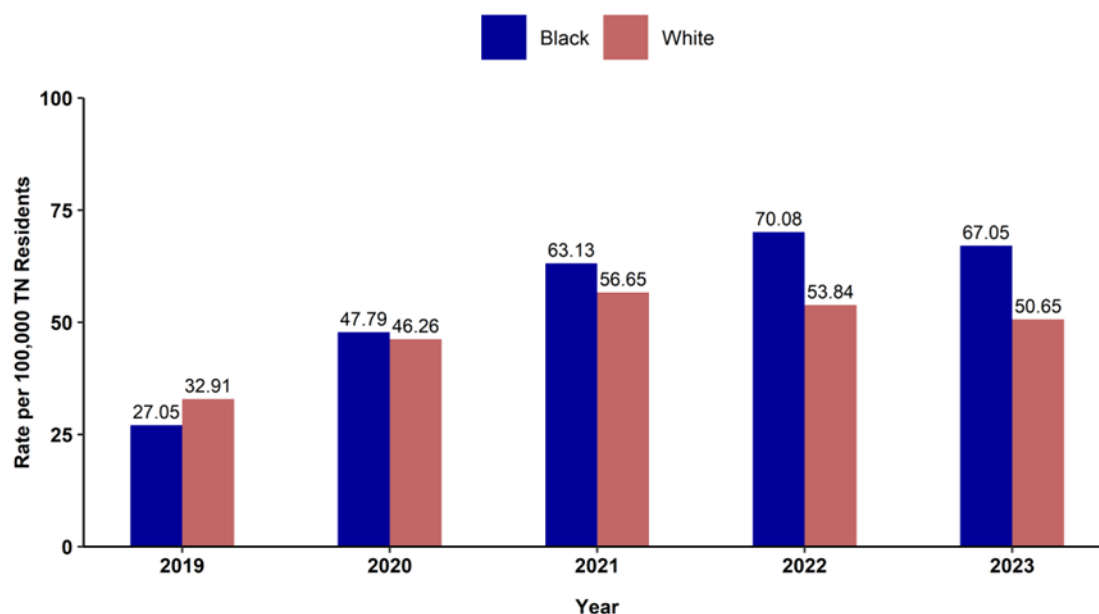
Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Race among TN Residents					
Race	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Black	317	549	735	817	777
White	1,721	2,413	2,990	2,881	2,718

In 2023, drug overdose deaths decreased for both Black and White Tennesseans. The proportion of White Tennesseans who died of a drug overdose decreased from 82% in 2019 to 75% in 2023. Conversely, the proportion of Black Tennesseans who died of an overdose increased from 15% in 2019 to 22% in 2023 indicating that the proportion of people dying from overdoses in Tennessee who are Black race is increasing.

Please see [page 34](#), the technical note section for recent changes in race calculation.

Age-Adjusted Rate of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Race among TN Residents, 2019-2023



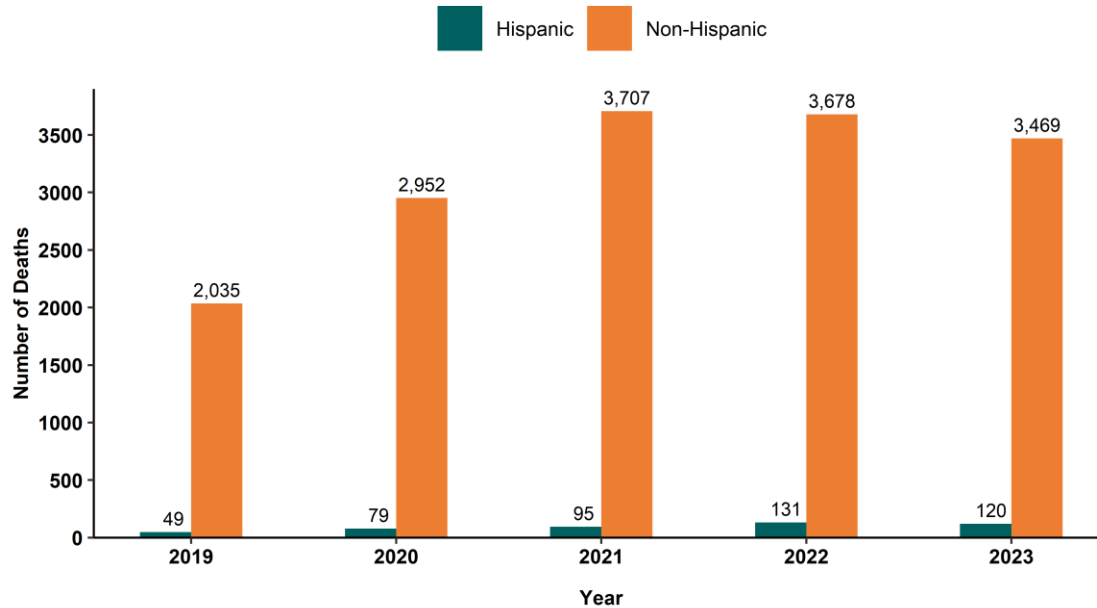
Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File. Population data is from CDC Wonder. 2022 population is used for the year 2023. Rates will be updated with 2023 population data when available.

Age-Adjusted Rate of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Race per 100,000 TN Residents					
Race	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Black	27.05	47.79	63.13	70.08	67.05
White	32.91	46.26	56.65	53.84	50.65

In 2020, the rate of overdose deaths among Black Tennesseans surpassed that of White Tennesseans. Rates of overdose deaths among both Black and White Tennesseans decreased in 2023, however, the rate among Black Tennesseans continues to be higher compared to White Tennesseans.

Please see [page 34](#), the technical note section for recent changes in race calculation.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Ethnicity among TN Residents, 2019-2023

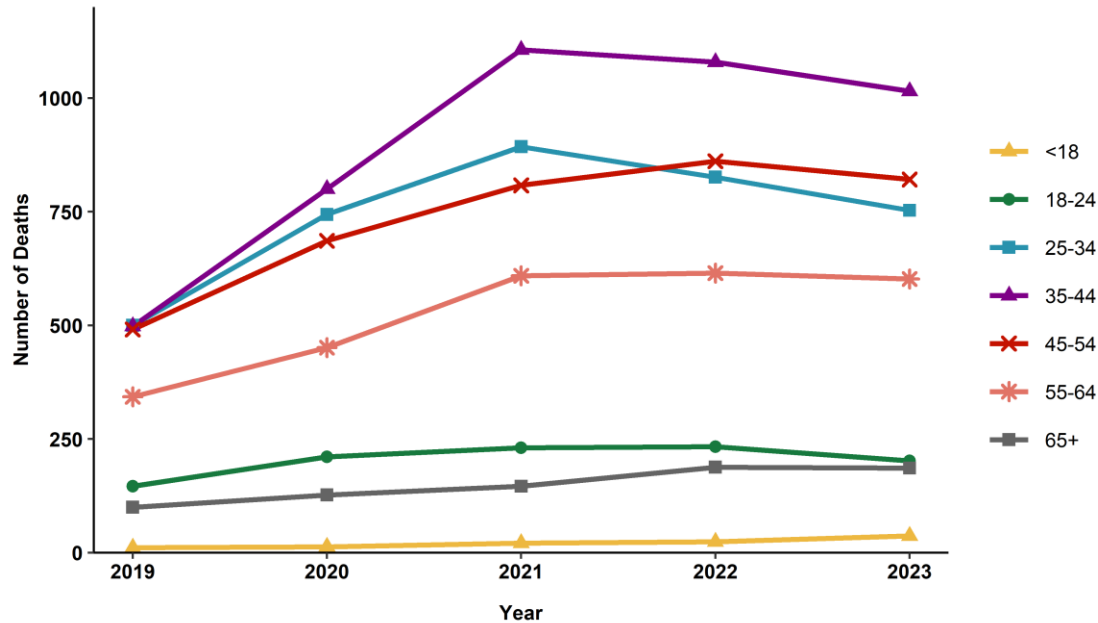


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of All Drug Overdoes Deaths by Ethnicity among TN Residents					
Ethnicity	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Hispanic	49	79	95	131	120
Non-Hispanic	2,035	2,952	3,707	3,678	3,469

In 2023, drug overdoses among Hispanic Tennesseans decreased 8%. However, between 2019 and 2023, drug overdose deaths involving Hispanic Tennesseans increased 145%. Over the five year time period, deaths among Hispanic Tennesseans have primarily involved opioids (fentanyl specifically) and stimulants (both cocaine and methamphetamine).

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Age Group among TN Residents, 2019-2023



Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

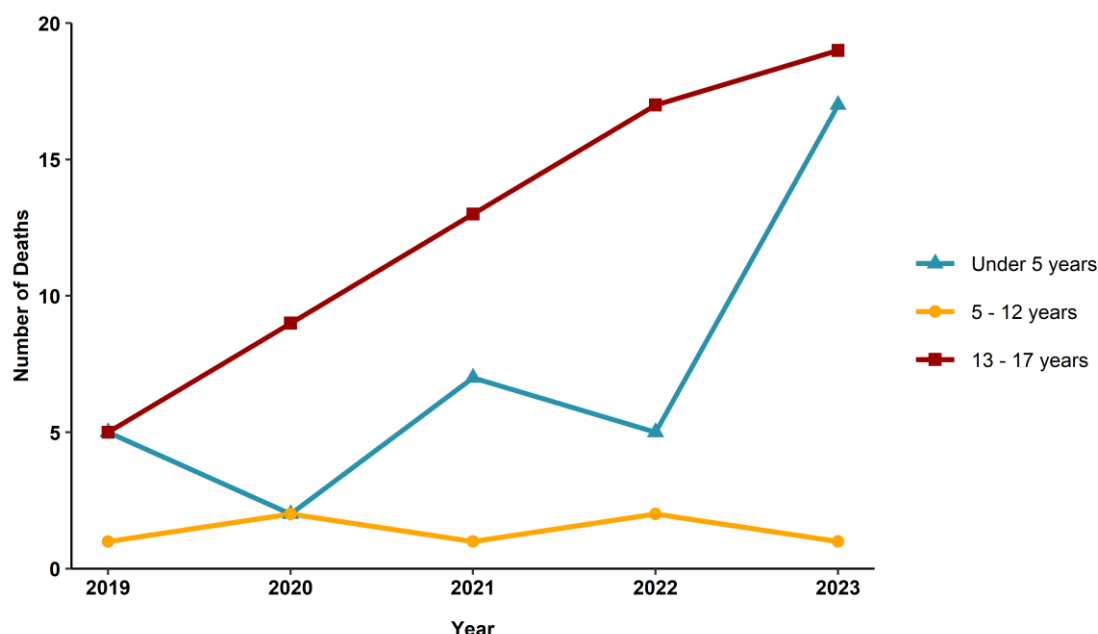
Number of Overdose Deaths among TN Residents by Age Group					
Age Category	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
<18	11	13	21	24	37
18-24	146	211	231	233	202
25-34	500	744	893	826	753
35-44	498	800	1,106	1,079	1,015
45-54	491	686	808	861	821
55-64	343	451	609	615	602
65+	100	127	146	188	186

In 2023, drug overdose deaths decreased for all age groups except for Tennessee residents less than 18 years of age who experienced a 54% increase. From 2019 to 2023, overdose deaths increased among all age groups. Between 2019 and 2023, persons aged 35-44 years had the highest percent increase (138%) of drug overdose deaths.

Examining the Increase in Overdose Deaths among TN Residents Under 18

In 2023, 37 Tennesseans under the age of 18 died of a drug overdose. Deaths in this age group have been increasing since 2019. Although the total number of deaths for those under 18 is small compared to other age groups, 'under 18' was the only age group to experience an increase in overdose deaths from 2022 to 2023.

Drug Overdose Deaths among TN Residents Under 18 Years of Age, 2019-2023



Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

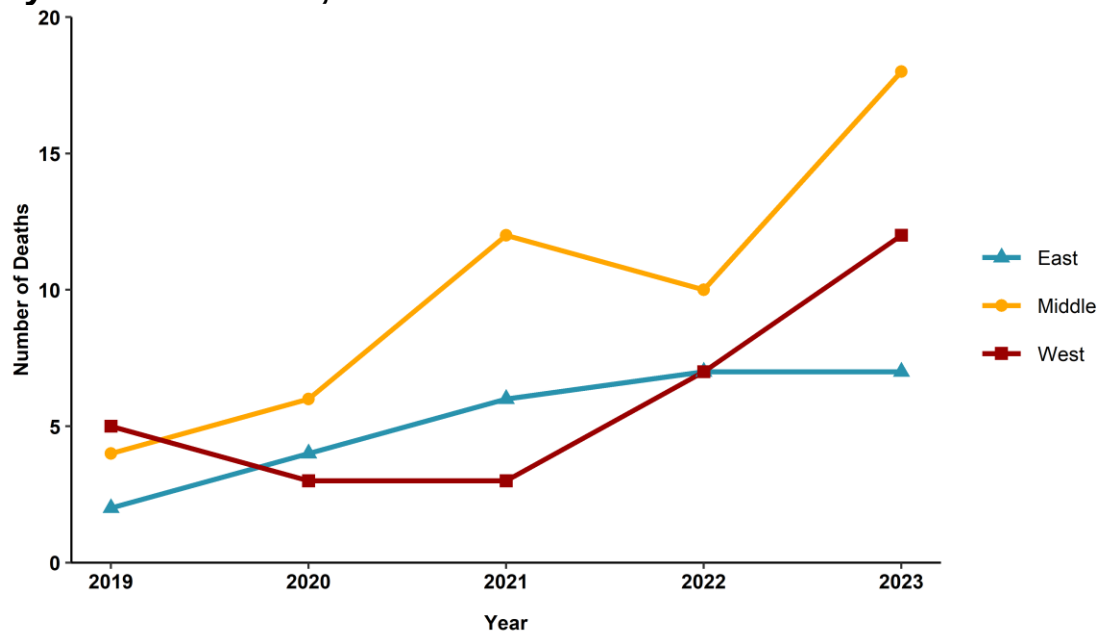
The visualization above shows the number of overdose deaths from 2019 to 2023 for Tennesseans less than 18 years grouped into three more-specific age groups: Under 5 (toddlers and infants), 5-12 (Elementary-age Children), 13-17 (Teens).

Number of Overdose Deaths among TN Residents Under 18 Years of Age					
Age Category	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Under 5 years	5	2	7	5	17
5 – 12 years	1	2	1	2	1
13 – 17 years	5	9	13	17	19
Total	11	13	21	24	37

From 2019 to 2023, the “13-17” age group consistently had the highest number of overdose deaths each year, followed by the “Under 5” age group and then the “5-12” age group. Each group showed a different pattern over the five-year period. Deaths in the “13-17” age group steadily increased each year. In the “5-12” age group, deaths varied slightly from year to year but remained low, ranging from 1 to 2 deaths annually. The “Under 5” age group also saw year-to-year changes, with a sharp increase from 5 deaths in 2022 to 17 deaths in 2023.

When considering the drugs that contributed to deaths of these youth in Tennessee, fentanyl was a primary cause of death. In 2023, approximately 80% of the under 18 overdose deaths involved fentanyl.

Drug Overdose Deaths among TN Residents Under 18 Years of Age by Grand Division, 2019-2023



Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

The graph above shows the location (by grand division) where Tennesseans under 18 years of age have had overdose deaths based on the individual’s reported residence. Unlike the adult population (18+ years of age), drug overdose deaths among Tennessee residents less than 18 years of age are highest in the Middle and West grand divisions for 2023. This age group also saw an increase in the number of overdose deaths in the Middle and West grand divisions from 2022 to 2023.

Summary and Resources to Learn More about Overdose Prevention in Youth

In 2023, Tennessee continued to see an increase in the number of overdose deaths among youth (those under 18). These deaths were primarily driven by accidental poisoning involving fentanyl in the 'under 5' and '13-17' age groups.

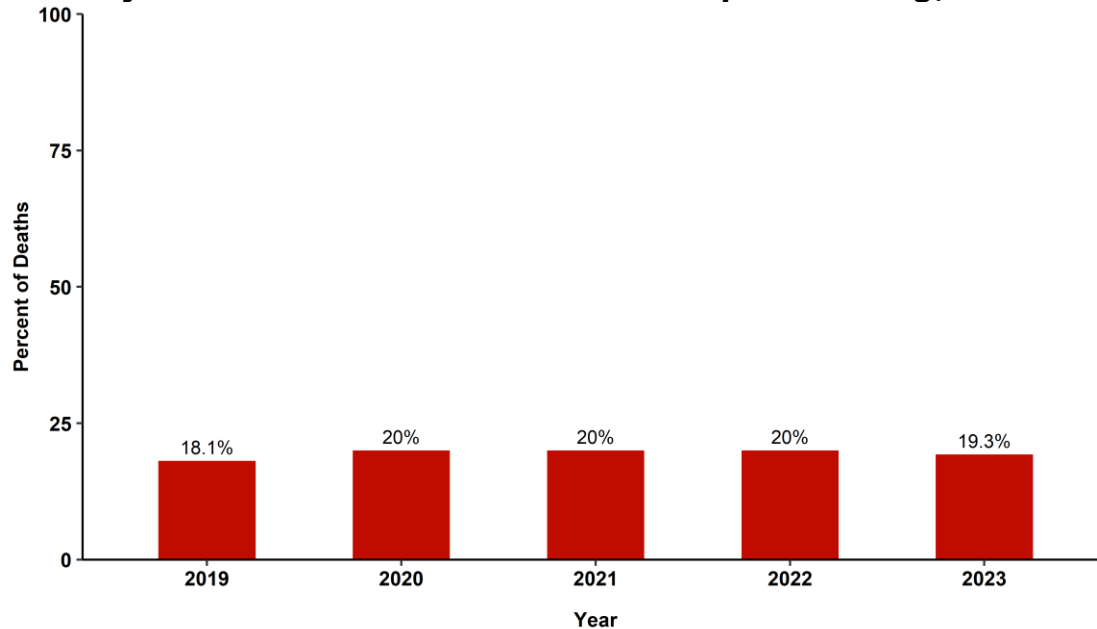
Youth overdose prevention strategies should be tailored to age-specific risks which when concerning fentanyl can be very different for toddlers compared to teens. For youth under five, both fatal and nonfatal overdoses are often due to accidental exposure, prevention strategies aimed at safe storage are critical such as promoting the use of lock boxes and ensuring dangerous substances are kept out of reach. In contrast, for teens (aged 13-17), prevention activities should emphasize education on the dangers of misusing prescription medications, counterfeit pills, illicit drugs, along with fostering open conversations about substance use risks and strategies to prevent harm between teens and trusted adults.

Below are more resources to learn about substance use in youth and evidence-based prevention strategies for youth:

- [Tennessee Together Student Survey](#)
 - o The Tennessee together student survey captures data on youth behaviors, attitudes, and social norms related to substances misuse, emotional wellness, and other risk behaviors among Tennessee 8th, 10th, and 12th grade public school students.
- [TDH Child Fatality Review Annual Report](#)
 - o Each report contains data that represents the review of eligible deaths in children under the age of 18 in Tennessee. In this report, information on overdose or poisoning deaths can be found.
- [PROTECT Initiative \(Safe Storage Strategies\)](#)
 - o The PRevention of Overdoses and Treatment Errors in Children Taskforce (PROTECT) initiative is an innovative collaboration bringing together public health agencies, private sector companies, professional organizations, consumer/patient advocates, and academic experts to develop strategies to keep children safe from unintentional overdoses.
- The Tennessee Department of Mental Health and Substance Abuse Services has numerous resources for substance use prevention, including 'information for parents' on the state's [prevention website](#).

Previous Nonfatal Overdoses among TN Residents, 2019 - 2023

Percent of People who had a Previous Nonfatal Drug Overdose in the 365 Days Prior to Death Treated in a Hospital Setting, 2019 - 2023

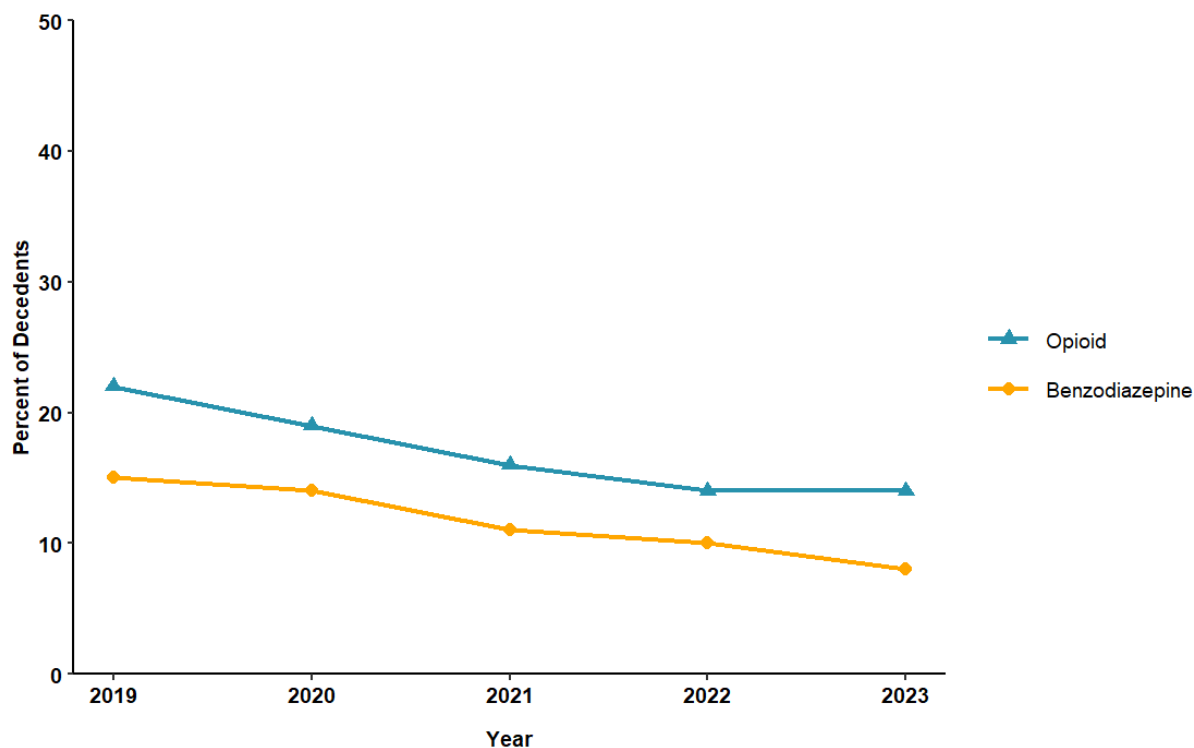


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File. Data linked to Hospital Discharge Data System Data. 92 % of deaths were able to be linked to discharge data.

In 2023, 19% of TN residents who died of a fatal drug overdose had a prior nonfatal drug overdose treated in a hospital setting in the year before death. This only includes nonfatal drug overdoses that were treated inpatient or outpatient in a hospital and does not include overdoses successfully reversed by Emergency Medical Services, First Responders, or personal naloxone. From 2019 to 2023, roughly one in five Tennesseans who died of a drug overdose were seen in a hospital setting demonstrating the importance of linkage to care efforts. Linkage to care efforts are coordinated by the TDH's Overdose Response Coordination Office (ORCO) as part of the Overdose Data to Action in States (OD2A-S) grant. See <https://www.tn.gov/health/orco/linkage-to-care.html> for more information.

Prescription History among Overdose Decedents for TN Residents

Prescription History in the 60 days Prior to Death for TN Residents, 2019 – 2023

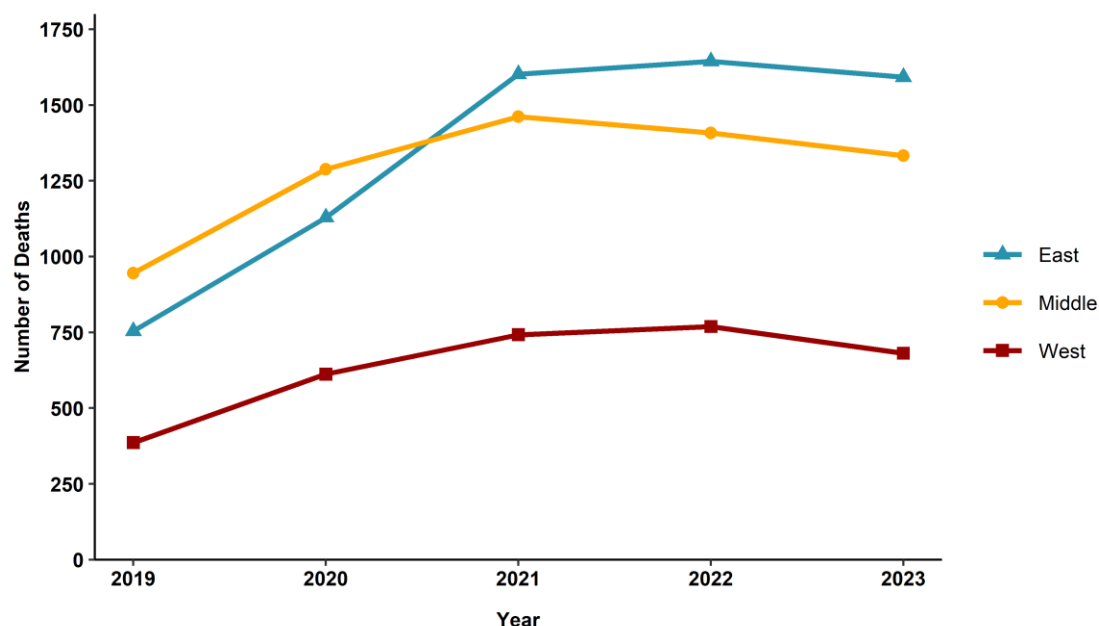


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File. Data linked to Controlled Substances Monitoring Program Database (CSMD) Data. 82% of deaths were able to be linked to CSMD data.

The proportion of drug overdose decedents filling opioid or benzodiazepine prescriptions in the 60 days prior to death has been decreasing since 2019. This corresponds with a decrease in overdose deaths attributed to prescription opioids. Additional prescription trends can be found in the appendices.

Geographical Data

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Grand Division among TN Residents, 2019-2023

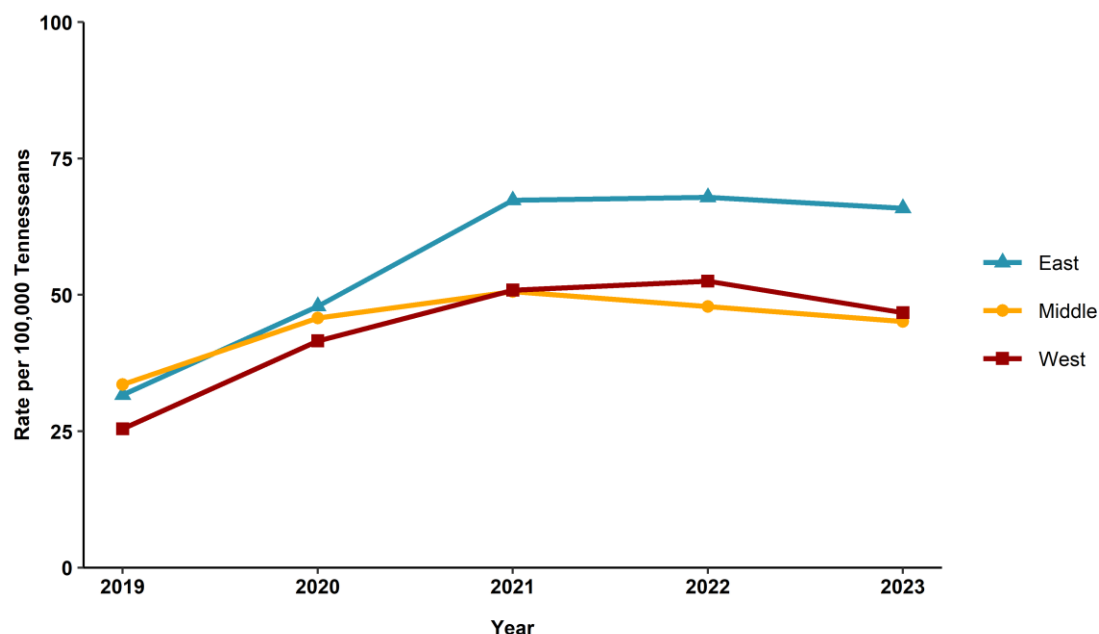


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Grand Division among TN Residents					
Grand Division	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
East	754	1,129	1,602	1,644	1,592
Middle	945	1,288	1,462	1,408	1,333
West	386	612	742	769	681

In 2023, drug overdose deaths decreased in all grand divisions, however, over the five year period, all grand divisions experienced an increase in overdose deaths.

Age-Adjusted Rate of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Grand Division among TN Residents, 2019-2023

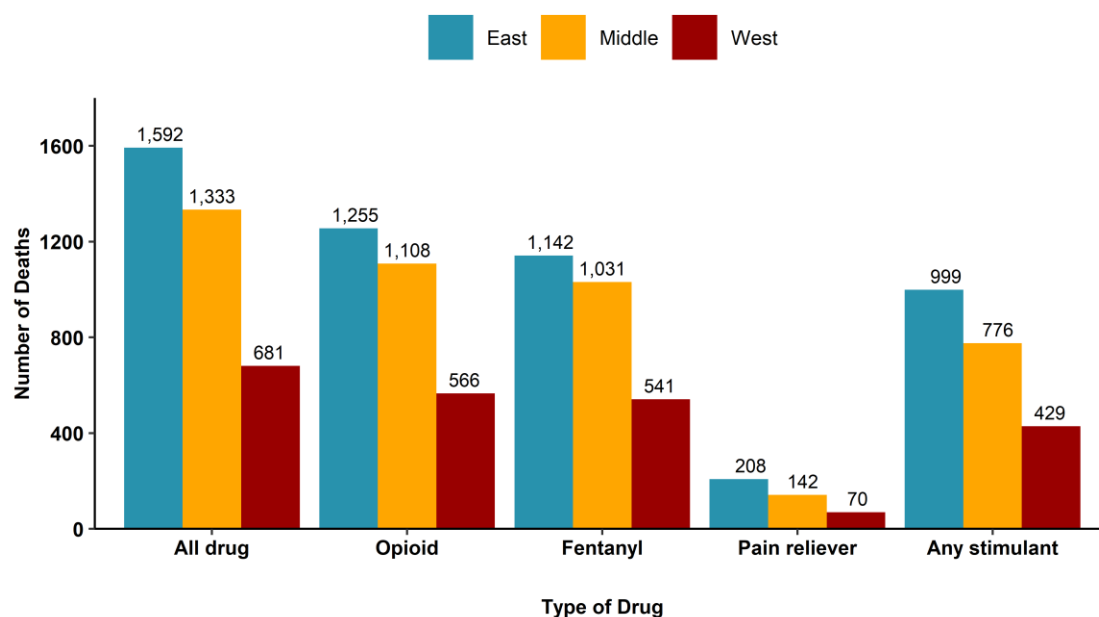


Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File. Population data is from CDC Wonder. 2022 population is used for the year 2023. Rates will be updated with 2023 population data when available.

Age-Adjusted Rates of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Grand Division per 100,000 TN Residents					
Grand Division	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
East	31.64	47.91	67.33	67.88	65.88
Middle	33.59	45.74	50.61	47.85	45.15
West	25.44	41.57	50.87	52.51	46.75

Age-adjusted rates of all drug overdose decreased in every grand division between 2022 and 2023. East Tennessee has had the highest age-adjusted rate of drug overdose deaths in Tennessee since 2022. In 2022, the age-adjusted rate of overdose in West Tennessee surpassed Middle Tennessee.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths* by Drug Type and Grand Division among TN Residents, 2023



Analysis by the Office of Informatics and Analytics, TDH (last updated February 13, 2025). Limited to TN residents. Data Source: TN Death Statistical File.

Number of All Drug Overdose Deaths by Type and Grand Division among TN Residents					
Grand Division	All Drug	Opioid	Fentanyl	Pain Reliever	Any Stimulant
East	1,592	1,255	1,142	208	999
Middle	1,333	1,108	1,031	142	776
West	681	566	541	70	429

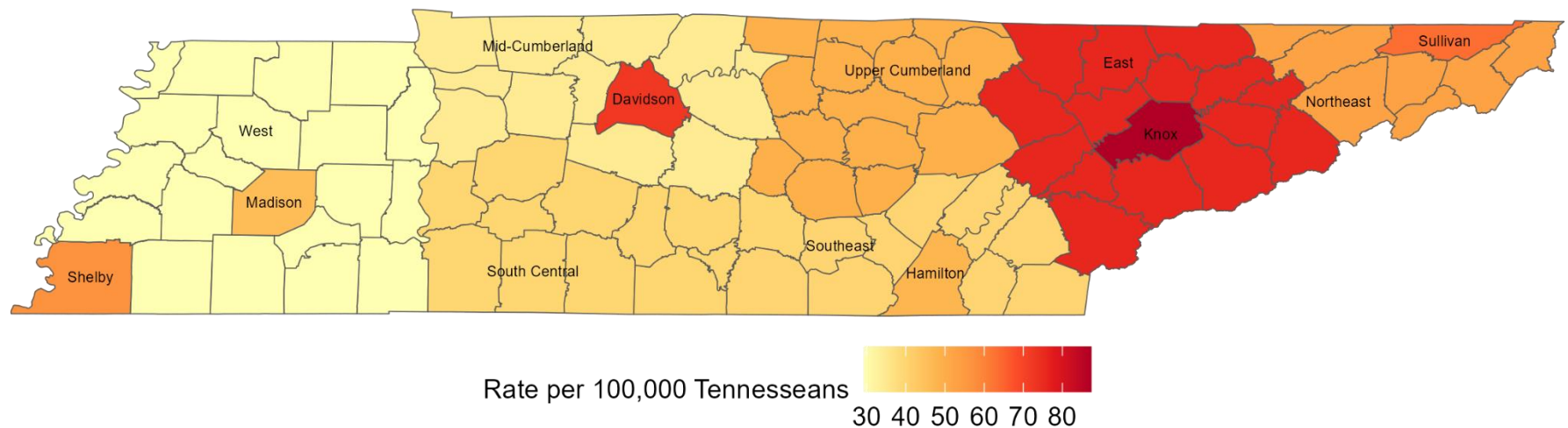
East TN had the highest number of overdose deaths, encompassing 44% of the deaths in 2023, followed by Middle and West grand divisions.

**Drug categories are not mutually exclusive. An overdose may have involved multiple types of opioids, non-opioids, or both. Due to improvement in text searches, opioid counts (fentanyl specifically) from previous years may be updated to reflect the new criteria.*

2023 Regional Level Data

Map: 2023 Age-Adjusted Rate of All Drug Overdose Deaths by TN Public Health Region of Residence

Knox metro had the highest rate of drug overdose deaths in 2023 followed by East Tennessee Region and Nashville Davidson Metro.



2023 County Level Data

The following pages include county data on the number of overdose deaths in 2023 by a subset of drug types*.

**Please note that the contributing drugs are not mutually exclusive and the counts of sub-categories of overdose death will not necessarily sum to total overdose deaths.*

2023 Overdose Death Counts by County of Residence

2023 Overdose Death Counts by County							
County	All Drug	Change from 2022	Opioid	Pain Reliever	Heroin	Fentanyl	Any Stimulant
Anderson	71	-4	62	15	0	57	49
Bedford	21	6	19	3	0	17	14
Benton	6	0	6	0	0	6	4
Bledsoe	3	0	2	1	0	2	2
Blount	64	-12	58	12	1	54	36
Bradley	37	-5	28	7	0	23	23
Campbell	30	-15	20	4	2	16	16
Cannon	6	-2	5	0	0	5	5
Carroll	8	2	5	0	0	5	3
Carter	33	-1	19	8	0	12	20
Cheatham	26	-17	25	1	0	25	16
Chester	3	1	1	0	0	1	1
Claiborne	32	11	12	2	0	11	10
Clay	3	1	1	1	0	1	1
Cocke	39	8	34	6	3	30	29
Coffee	27	2	19	4	1	17	11
Crockett	1	-1	0	0	0	0	1
Cumberland	46	1	34	5	0	33	30
Davidson	533	-7	465	52	4	440	327
DeKalb	14	4	13	0	0	13	10
Decatur	6	3	4	2	0	3	5
Dickson	25	-7	21	1	0	20	13
Dyer	5	-2	4	0	0	3	3
Fayette	13	-2	11	0	0	11	4
Fentress	11	0	7	2	0	4	6
Franklin	12	0	8	1	0	7	4
Gibson	10	-3	5	0	0	5	7
Giles	9	-2	7	1	0	6	7

2023 Tennessee Drug Overdose Deaths

2023 Overdose Death Counts by County							
County	All Drug	Change from 2022	Opioid	Pain Reliever	Heroin	Fentanyl	Any Stimulant
Grainger	16	-1	10	3	1	6	12
Greene	47	9	33	7	0	31	33
Grundy	7	0	3	0	0	3	6
Hamblen	39	4	34	4	1	30	25
Hamilton	174	-10	135	8	0	128	110
Hancock	8	4	3	0	0	3	7
Hardeman	12	3	9	0	0	9	10
Hardin	8	-4	3	1	0	3	4
Hawkins	17	-8	10	2	0	9	14
Haywood	4	2	3	1	0	3	3
Henderson	7	-4	5	1	0	4	4
Henry	8	1	4	1	0	4	4
Hickman	20	0	13	2	0	12	15
Houston	3	-2	3	0	0	3	2
Humphreys	9	-1	6	2	0	4	5
Jackson	5	-1	3	0	0	3	2
Jefferson	35	2	25	5	1	24	22
Johnson	9	-5	6	0	0	4	8
Knox	430	-31	361	52	8	343	284
Lake	6	2	5	1	0	4	3
Lauderdale	6	-6	5	0	0	5	4
Lawrence	20	1	16	3	0	14	8
Lewis	2	-7	1	0	0	1	1
Lincoln	5	-3	4	0	0	4	2
Loudon	37	12	34	8	0	27	19
Macon	10	-6	8	3	0	6	5
Madison	42	9	34	7	1	32	20
Marion	10	-9	9	2	0	8	2
Marshall	11	-3	10	0	0	10	7
Maury	38	-1	33	5	1	29	23
McMinn	27	0	17	2	1	16	11
McNairy	5	-3	4	0	0	4	3
Meigs	4	-7	1	0	0	1	4
Monroe	32	-3	27	6	1	24	17
Montgomery	76	-5	63	5	0	62	45
Moore	1	-1	1	1	0	0	0
Morgan	20	8	18	4	1	17	14
Obion	5	-1	3	0	0	2	1
Overton	9	2	9	2	0	7	7
Perry	2	-3	2	1	0	1	0
Pickett	1	0	0	0	0	0	0

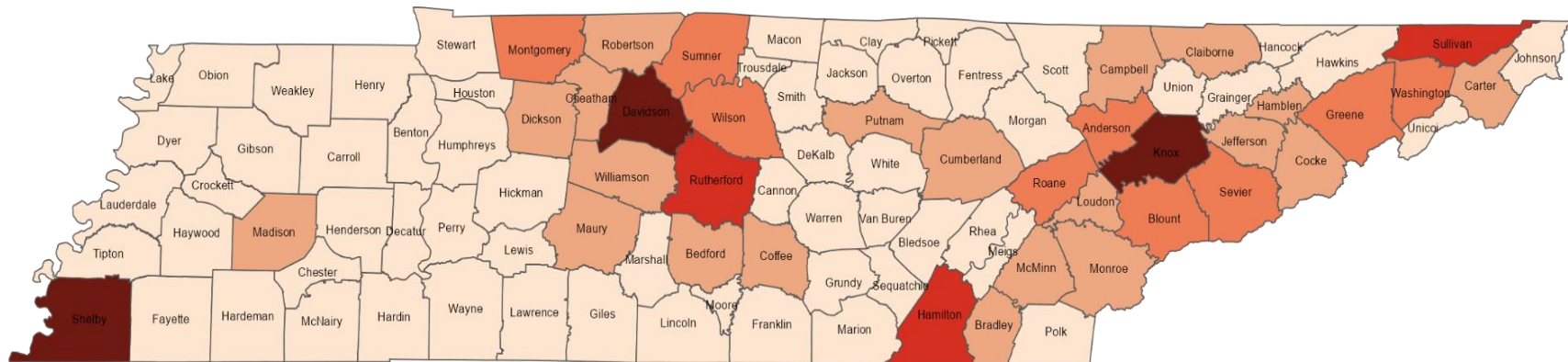
2023 Tennessee Drug Overdose Deaths

2023 Overdose Death Counts by County							
County	All Drug	Change from 2022	Opioid	Pain Reliever	Heroin	Fentanyl	Any Stimulant
Polk	12	8	11	2	0	10	5
Putnam	32	3	29	5	0	27	22
Rhea	13	-11	8	2	0	8	4
Roane	72	13	61	6	0	58	53
Robertson	46	10	38	2	0	37	28
Rutherford	114	-16	95	12	1	92	64
Scott	5	1	4	0	0	4	4
Sequatchie	5	-3	5	1	0	4	1
Sevier	53	-18	46	8	1	43	24
Shelby	499	-78	431	52	2	415	328
Smith	4	-9	4	0	0	4	3
Stewart	5	-2	4	1	0	4	2
Sullivan	93	16	69	12	0	59	57
Sumner	68	7	51	3	1	49	37
Tipton	20	-6	19	4	0	17	12
Trousdale	5	-3	5	0	0	5	2
UNKNOWN	10		7	2	0	6	8
Unicoi	6	-2	4	0	0	2	2
Union	13	-4	8	1	0	7	5
Van Buren	3	2	1	0	0	1	3
Warren	15	-6	7	4	0	4	9
Washington	65	-3	52	14	0	42	48
Wayne	12	8	9	2	0	8	5
Weakley	7	-1	5	0	0	5	5
White	11	-7	5	0	0	5	11
Williamson	39	-7	31	11	0	25	12
Wilson	68	0	59	11	0	52	35
TENNESSEE	3,616	-210	2,936	422	32	2,720	2,212

Map: 2023 All Drug Overdose Deaths by TN County of Residence

In 2023, every county in Tennessee experienced a drug overdose death. The map below shows the counts occurring in each county.

We do not show rates for fatal overdoses on the map because when the count is less than 10, the rate becomes unstable and is not a reliable estimate. To see the rate information for counties where the estimate is reliable, please see our data dashboard, <https://www.tn.gov/health/health-program-areas/pdo/pdo/data-dashboard.html>.



Count of all drug overdose deaths per county

Color	Count Range
Light Orange	1 - 20
Orange	21 - 46
Dark Orange	47 - 81
Red	82 - 184
Dark Brown	185 - 533

Technical Notes: Tennessee Drug Overdose Deaths Indicator

Categories of drug overdose are identified as follows:

Category	Criteria
Primary Criteria	Only Tennessee residents
	Excludes voided death certificates
All Drug Overdose	Deaths that have been coded with any of the following ICD-10 codes as the underlying cause of death:
	X40-X44: Accidental poisoning by drugs
	X60-X64: Intentional self-poisoning by drugs
	X85: Assault by drug poisoning
	Y10-Y14: Drug poisoning of undetermined intent
Drug Overdose Deaths Involving Opioids	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain at least one of the following ICD-10 codes as a contributing cause of death:
	T40.0: Poisoning by opium
	T40.1: Poisoning by heroin
	T40.2: Poisoning by natural and semisynthetic opioids
	T40.3: Poisoning by methadone
	T40.4: Poisoning by synthetic opioids other than methadone
	T40.6: Poisoning by other and unspecified narcotics
	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain the following text in the contributing cause of death text fields: 'FENTAN', 'FENTA', 'FANTAN' and some other misspellings when no opioid code is available
Drug Overdose Deaths Involving Opioid Pain Relievers	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain at least one of the following ICD-10 codes as a contributing cause of death:
	T40.2: Poisoning by natural and semisynthetic opioids
	T40.3: Poisoning by methadone
Drug Overdose Deaths Involving Heroin	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain the following ICD-10 code as a contributing cause of death:
	T40.1: Poisoning by heroin
Drug Overdose Deaths Involving Fentanyl	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain the following text in the contributing cause of death text fields: 'FENTAN', 'FENTA', 'FANTAN' and some other misspellings
Drug Overdose Deaths Involving Any Stimulant	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain the following ICD-10 code as a contributing cause of death:
	T43.6: Poisoning by psychostimulants with abuse potential or
	T40.5: Poisoning by cocaine
Drug Overdose Deaths Involving Benzodiazepine	Must meet criteria for All Drug Overdose deaths AND contain the following ICD-10 code as a contributing cause of death:
	T42.4: Poisoning by benzodiazepine

Additional Resources

Data Resources

The Office of Informatics and Analytics offers a variety of reports on its Facts & Figures page on the TDH website (<https://www.tn.gov/health/health-program-areas/pdo/pdo/facts-figures.html>)

The Tennessee Department of Health has curated a TDH Health Data Portal website. This platform allows you to search, explore, download, and share public health data. (<https://healthdata.tn.gov/>)

For data not available in this report or on the TDH website, please submit a request through the TDH Data Request System on the TDH data portal(<https://healthdata.tn.gov/stories/s/puqi-g78j>)

Resources for Treatment and Prevention

- The Overdose Response Coordination Office (ORCO) supports the Department's overdose prevention and response efforts, oversees grant-funded activities and cultivates and expands partnerships to strengthen the state's public health response to the overdose crisis. ORCO oversees public health interventions across the continuum of care including provider education, community overdose prevention education, coordinating overdose monitoring and response, harm reduction and navigation to treatment and recovery resources from local health departments, correctional settings and emergency departments. For more information on ORCO programs and efforts, see <https://www.tn.gov/health/orco.html>.
- Find Help Now is a national platform where individuals can locate substance use disorder treatment options in their communities, see <https://findhelpnow.org/tn>.
- The Tennessee REDLINE is a 24/7/365 resource for Substance Use Disorder treatment referrals. Anyone can call or text 800-889-9789 for confidential referrals.
- The Tennessee Statewide Crisis Line, available 24 hours a day/365 days a year, is a free resource for anyone experiencing a mental health crisis. All calls are routed to a trained local crisis counselor who provides support and guidance and will work to connect the caller with appropriate community support. Call 855-CRISIS-1 (855-274-7471).
- The 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline is also available 24 hours a day/365 days a year and provides one-on-one assistance with a trained counselor. Call 988.
- For Tennesseans actively in recovery from substance use disorder or for those looking for more information about its prevention, the Tennessee Department of Mental Health and Substance Abuse Services (TDMHSAS) offers the TN Recover App. This app is available for download in the Apple Store, the Google Play store, or by texting 'SAVE' to 30678.

- For overdose prevention training, tools and resources, the Regional Overdose Prevention Specialists (ROPS) are located throughout the state as a point of contact for overdose prevention and tool such as naloxone and testing strips. To learn more about the ROPS work or to contact your local ROPS, see <https://www.tn.gov/behavioral-health/substance-abuse-services/prevention/rops.html>
- Naloxone, commonly known as Narcan, is a lifesaving medication used to reverse the effects of opioids, including fentanyl. Naloxone is available at local health departments, see <https://www.tn.gov/health/health-program-areas/localdepartments.html>.
- TDMHSAS has developed resources about overdose and naloxone for individuals and agencies. Find this at <https://www.tn.gov/behavioral-health/substance-abuse-services/prevention/naloxone-training-information.html>.
- In counties and communities across Tennessee, substance use prevention coalitions are working to reduce dependence on harmful and potentially lethal substances, such as prescription drugs, alcohol, and tobacco. These local efforts, funded by the State of Tennessee since 2008, help spread the word about the dangers and consequences of substance use. To connect with a local coalition, see <https://www.tn.gov/behavioral-health/substance-abuse-services/prevention/anti-drug-coalition.html>.
- Fentanyl and fentanyl-involved overdoses are a significant concern across the state of Tennessee. While fentanyl is dangerous, overdoses involving fentanyl are preventable with the right knowledge and tools. To learn about fentanyl, TDMHSAS has created fentanyl specific resources and trainings available for all Tennesseans. Find these at <https://www.tn.gov/behavioral-health/substance-abuse-services/prevention/fentanyl.html>.
- The drug supply is constantly changing and staying informed about the current landscape can be lifesaving. TDMHSAS has created resources about xylazine and provides information about emerging trends throughout the year. Current training opportunities and resources can be found at <https://www.tn.gov/behavioral-health/substance-abuse-services/prevention/emerging-substances.html>.
- Syringe Services Programs (SSPs) provide comprehensive harm reduction services including providing free sterile needles, syringes, and other injection equipment; safe disposal containers; HIV and viral hepatitis testing and linkage to treatment; overdose prevention and education; referrals to substance use disorder treatment, medical providers, and social services; and HIV, STIs, and viral hepatitis prevention education. To learn more about SSP's and where they are located in TN, see <https://www.tn.gov/health/health-program-areas/std/std/syringe-services-program.html>.

- TN Together is a system designed specifically to engage and empower Tennesseans to combat substance use in their community. It is an interactive online resource hub with a 3-part goal: to provide examples of prevention activities, to showcase how other communities have been successful in prevention, and to access up-to-date addiction and recovery resources. To access this online hub: <https://tntogether.com/>.

Appendices

Important Note for Race Variable Calculation

Single-race White and single-race Black are represented in the report for all years of data. Previous reports included multiple-race responses that had been bridged to White or Black in the respective White or Black counts. That bridging was done according to the methods outlined in the Center for Disease Control (CDC) National Center for Health Statistics (NCHS) “Procedures for Multiple-race and Hispanic Origin Data: Collection, Coding, Editing, and Transmitting”.

NCHS discontinued race bridging beginning with 2022 data. Previous reports also imputed the race as White for Hispanic decedents for which the race was not classifiable in one or more of the OMB’s five minimum categories for data on race (i.e. with a race of ‘some other race’). Therefore, counts by race in previous reports will be higher than the counts published here to the extent that records previously classified as White or Black no longer meet the revised criteria.

The race categories used in this report also differ from those used by NCHS in current publications, including drug overdose reports. Like this report, NCHS now uses single-race categories, but NCHS assigns the race of all records for which race unknown, not stated, or not classifiable to the racial designation of the previous single-race records.

Prescription History Appendices

Prescription History in the 365 Days Before Overdose Death* among TN Residents, 2019-2023

Percent who filled any prescription in the TN CSMD within 365 days of death by type of overdose among all individuals who died, 2019-2023

(total n=16,377, total linked n=13,402)

Type	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
All Drug	53	48	44	41	38
All Opioid	53	47	44	40	38
Pain Relievers	63	62	60	59	55
Benzodiazepine	66	66	60	62	56
Heroin	49	47	44	38	38
Fentanyl	49	44	42	38	36
Opioid and Benzodiazepine	66	65	59	61	56

The CSMD provides insight on the controlled substances prescribed to Tennesseans who died from a drug overdose. The table above shows the percentage of overdose decedents who filled any controlled substance prescription in the 365 day period before their death. Overdose deaths are further divided into categories by the drug involved in the death. For example, in 2023, 38% of individuals who died of an opioid overdose had filled any controlled substance prescription (reported to the CSMD) in the past year, compared to 22% doing so in the 60 days before death (see next page). **Categories of drug deaths are not mutually exclusive.*

Prescription History in the 60 Days Before Overdose Death* among TN Residents, 2019-2023

Percent who filled any prescription in the TN CSMD within 60 days of death by type of overdose among all individuals who died, 2019-2023

(total n=16,377, total linked n=13,402)

Type	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
All Drug	34	31	27	24	22
All Opioid	34	30	26	24	22
Pain Relievers	47	47	42	42	39
Benzodiazepine	52	51	46	50	41
Heroin	27	29	23	25	16
Fentanyl	28	25	24	21	19
Opioid and Benzodiazepine	52	50	45	48	41

The table above shows the percentage of overdose decedents who filled any controlled substance prescription in the 60 day period before their death. Overdose deaths are further divided into categories by the drug involved in the death. From 2019 to 2023, there has been a continual decrease in the percentage of decedents who filled a prescription in the CSMD in the 60 days before death for most categories. For example, in 2019, 34% of overdose decedents filled a prescription in the 60 days before death, but by 2023 that number dropped to just 22%. These trends reflect the decrease in deaths involving prescription opioids and increase involving illicit opioids; the current driving force behind the fatal overdose epidemic. **Categories of drug deaths are not mutually exclusive.*

Opioid and Benzodiazepine Prescription History in the 60 Days Before Overdose Death* among TN Residents, 2019-2023

Percent who filled any prescription in the TN CSMD within 60 days of death by type of overdose among all individuals who died, 2019-2023

(total n=16,377, total linked n=13,402)

Type	Opioid prescription filled					Benzodiazepine prescription filled				
	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
All Drug	22	19	16	14	14	15	14	11	10	8
All Opioid	23	18	17	14	14	15	14	11	10	8
Pain Relievers	36	34	30	28	30	23	24	20	19	15
Benzodiazepine	30	28	23	24	21	38	38	34	26	28
Heroin	18	18	12	18	6	13	11	8	12	6
Fentanyl	18	15	15	12	12	11	11	9	8	7
Opioid and Benzodiazepine	32	28	23	26	23	38	37	32	33	27

The table above shows the percentage of overdose decedents who filled an opioid or benzodiazepine prescription in the 60 day period before their death. Overdose deaths are further divided into categories by the drug involved in the death. For example, in 2023, 14% of all drug overdose decedents had filled an opioid prescription in the 60 days before death, a 36% decrease from 2019. **Categories of drug deaths are not mutually exclusive.*